

a "gradual" process—one he credits to therapy and a drive for inventive solutions. "Choosing your workmates well is virtually half the battle won," adds Banerjee.

The disappearance of *Tees* may be best understood in the context of the controversy that surrounded *Tandav* (2021), the Prime Video series that drew right-wing ire for its portrayal of dissent and religious imagery. Despite edits, legal cases mounted, and fear took hold. It sent a clear warning to streamers, who became increasingly cautious about supporting projects that might provoke similar backlash. In such a fragile climate, films like *Tees* have arguably become collateral damage.

According to Banerjee, filmmaking is an expensive art form that demands "mediated investment" but which become an easy target because of its ability to reach out to a massive audience. Suppressing art that focuses on truth-telling, questioning and challenging narratives is a surefire way to condition audiences in the practice of distraction. "A generation growing up on moving images can be better controlled if cruelty, misogyny and empty spectacle are provided through films regularly," he argues.

Simply by existing, *Tees* defies that conditioning. Invisibilising it makes clear exactly which stories are unwelcome in India today. And yet, its disappearance has only amplified the urgency of what it had to say. ■

—Poulomi Das

CINEMA ▼

Healing in the Himalayas



SUBHADRA MAHAJAN'S B&W FEATURE—*SECOND CHANCE*—IS FINALLY HITTING INDIAN THEATRES

Battling the trauma of an illicit abortion, a woman retreats into the cold white of her Himalayan hometown in Subhadra Mahajan's poetic feature debut *Second Chance*. It has been doing the rounds of festivals since last year. Starring newcomers and non-actors, and shot entirely in black and white, Mahajan's microbudget film is having an unlikely theatrical release across India on June 13.

"It was a dream that this could be seen in theatres," says Mahajan. "Something like this could be released in European countries perhaps, but *Second Chance* getting an Indian theatrical release is all because of distributor Shiladitya Bora."

Bora's resume includes backing bold works such as *Masaan* and *Newton*. *Second Chance* will first release in key cities like Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru, Pune and Kochi, and expanding in subsequent weeks. Bora says, "We used a similar model for Anamika Haksar's Sundance winner *Ghode Ko Jalebi Khilane Le Ja Riya Hoon*, which had a successful run for 56 days in Indian theatres."

***Second Chance* was shot in January and February of 2022 in Himachal Pradesh's Naggar and Lahaul. The opening scene was shot when the temperature was -20°C. Battling the biting winter was a small 12-person crew, plus three actors and three drivers.**

About shooting the film in black and white, Mahajan says that is how she envisioned it while writing. "The central protagonist is finding light at the end of a very long and dark tunnel," the Shimla-born filmmaker explains. "We always see the Himalayas in full colour in every season. As somebody born and raised there, and I do a bit of photography, I noticed that this particular valley in the winter is really beautiful."

As inspirations, Mahajan credits Iranian New Wave filmmakers Majid Majidi and Abbas Kiarostami, particularly their use of non-actors. While lead actor Dheera Johnson is a newcomer, Thakri Devi and Kanav Thakur are non-actor locals. Mahajan also took inspiration from Ansel Adams's B&W photography and Andrea Arnold's films such as *American Honey* and *Fish Tank*, which have "imperfect, young, female protagonists".

"Black and white should not be considered a limitation," she says. "There are million shades of greyness and monotone that are the entire spectrum of life in a way." ■

—Devarsi Ghosh

A NEW WAVE
Shot in Himachal Pradesh, the film stars newcomers and non-actors

